

REFLECTION

What Do We Get When We Make Du'a?

Three answers, and what du'a does for us

Someone once asked me whether du'a (دُعَاء, "calling on Allah") really works. Here is my answer, from the Qur'an, the Sunnah, and some thought about it.

Every sincere du'a is answered

Allah says: ادْعُونِي أَسْتَجِبْ لَكُمْ "Call on Me; I will answer you" (40:60). The Prophet ﷺ explained how. Abu Sa'id al-Khudri reported that he said: "There is no Muslim who calls on Allah with a du'a that has no sin in it and no cutting of family ties, except that Allah gives him one of three things: He answers it quickly, or He stores it for him in the Hereafter, or He turns away from him an evil like it." The companions said, "Then we will ask for more." He said, "Allah has more." (Musnad Ahmad; authentic)

- **You get what you asked for,** now or later.
- **A harm is turned away** that you never knew was coming.
- **It is saved for you** for the Day you need it most.

And sometimes what we ask for would hurt us. In Surah Al-Baqarah (2:216):

وَعَسَىٰ أَن تَكْرَهُوا شَيْئًا وَهُوَ خَيْرٌ لَّكُمْ ۖ وَعَسَىٰ أَن تُحِبُّوا شَيْئًا وَهُوَ شَرٌّ لَّكُمْ ۗ وَاللَّهُ يَعْلَمُ وَأَنتُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ ﴿٢١٦﴾

"Perhaps you dislike something and it is good for you, and perhaps you love something and it is bad for you. Allah knows, and you do not know."

Du'a and action

Du'a is not a replacement for effort. Allah does not usually set aside His own laws of cause and effect for us. A student who makes du'a and does not study should not expect the exam to change. But du'a changes us:

1. It gives peace and contentment, so we can get busy with the work.
2. It keeps the goal in front of us and reminds us to act.
3. It gives courage, because we know our Creator is with us.

And Allah knows best.

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